

CHAPTER II

GANDHIJI'S IDEAS ON EDUCATION

BEFORE we proceed to examine the Wardha Scheme of Education, in order to arrive at a true conception of it and to grasp its various details and distinguishing features, we must be thoroughly acquainted with its background and foundations. The basic ideas of the Wardha Scheme are the ideas of Gandhiji on education. With the help of his articles in *Harijan*, we are able to get at his mind, and by quoting his own words as well as the words of those who have understood his mind, I shall attempt to throw light on the many features and details of the scheme in the subsequent chapters. Let us first understand the mind of Gandhiji—his ideas on the various aspects of the educational problem.

I. Defects of the Present System

According to him, 'the present primary education is a snare and a delusion' (*Harijan*, September 18, 1937). In his inaugural address at the Conference, he expressed himself with still greater clearness, when he said: 'I am convinced that the present system of primary education is not only wasteful but positively harmful. Most of the boys are lost to the parents and to the occupation to which they are born. They pick up evil habits, affect urban ways and get a smattering of something which may be anything but education.'

The same view on the present system of education was emphasized and more completely brought out by Sri Mashruwala, who wrote in *Harijan* (December 4, 1937):

Under the present system most pupils do not, even at the end of their college career, know what they will do after completing their studies. Young boys and girls, unless their material circumstances are hopelessly adverse, pass on from primary to secondary schools, and from secondary schools to colleges, at an enormous expense, not for the love of cultural and other education which the schools and colleges profess to give, but simply because they do not know what else they should or could do. They go on with their studies merely in order to put off till the last day the difficult question of settling the main career of life. More than twenty years of the growing period of life spent in such aimless manner, must inculcate in the pupils habits of procrastination, hesitation, irresoluteness and inability to take decisions in the pursuits of life.

The Honble Sri Viswanath Das, former Minister for Education, Orissa, forcibly brought out some other evils too, when he said at the Conference:

Education is not worth its name unless it is national and useful. The present system of education that is imparted in our schools is neither the one nor the other. It is a system of instruction which kills the creative genius of the boy and the man, both at school and at college. The ideal of education is to bring out the best in man, to create a love for God and for man. Judged by these standards, education imparted in this country falls far short of its ideal.

These are some of the evils of the present system of education which the scheme proposes to eradicate.

II. True Education

Now what is the idea of true education according to Gandhiji? We have it in his own words. He says: 'By education I mean an all-round drawing out of the best in child and man—body, mind and spirit. Literacy is not the end of education nor even the beginning. It is only one of the means whereby man and woman can be educated. Literacy in itself is no education.' (*Harijan*, July 31, 1937.)

This conception of education is amplified in a later article, under the caption: 'Four Things Necessary' (*Harijan*, October 11, 1937):

The modulation of the voice is as necessary as the training of the hand. Physical drill, handicrafts, drawing and music should go hand in hand in order to draw the best out of the boys and girls and create in them a real interest in their tuition.

That this means a revolution in the system of training is admitted. If the future citizens of the State are to build a sure foundation for life's work, these four things are necessary. One has only to visit any primary school to have a striking demonstration of slovenliness, disorderliness and discordant speech. I have no doubt, therefore, that when the Education Ministers in the several provinces recast the system of education and make it answer the requirements of the country, they will not omit the essentials to which I have drawn attention. My plan of primary education certainly comprises these things which easily become possible the moment you remove from the children's shoulders the burden of having to master a difficult foreign language.

The statement 'literacy in itself is no education', made by Gandhiji, may not be clear to all. We shall, therefore, reproduce another passage from the long and enlightening article of Sri Mashruwala, from which

another extract was made earlier (*Harijan*, December 4, 1937):

In the Segaon Method,¹ literacy (that is, information on various matters through reading and writing, and capacity to follow logical or pseudo-logical controversy) is not considered knowledge or even the medium of knowledge, but is regarded only as a symbolical representation both of knowledge and of accomplished ignorance. The knowledge of these symbols is necessary and useful, if the sources of knowledge are alive. It will be the aim of the Segaon Method to keep these sources alive. The means of doing so are work, observation, experience, experiment, service and love. Without these, learning through books acts as a hindrance to the development of the spiritual and rational faculties of the student, and also impairs his physique.

III. Two Propositions

With the ideas enunciated above as background, Mahatmaji formulated two propositions upon which he built the whole of his Wardha Scheme of Education.

1. Primary education, extending over a period of seven years or longer, and covering all the subjects up to the matriculation standard except English, plus a vocation used as a vehicle for drawing out the minds of the boys and girls in all departments of knowledge, should take the place of what passes today under the name of primary, middle, and high school education.

¹ The expression 'Segaon Method' is another way of referring to the Wardha Scheme—*Segaon*, because that is the name of the village where Mahatma Gandhi now lives and where he planned the scheme; and *Wardha*, because the Conference which approved his scheme met in the town of Wardha (in the Central Provinces). The village of Segaon is five miles from Wardha. Its name has recently been changed to Sewagram.

- ✓ 2. Such education, taken as a whole, can and must be self-supporting; in fact, self-support is the acid test of its reality. (*Harijan*, October 2, 1937.)

These two propositions he recommended to the careful consideration of the educationists of the country.

IV. His Convictions

That the scheme, though novel, is bound to succeed is the conviction of Gandhiji, who has had some personal experience in the matter. That he recommended it to the consideration of the educationists of the country out of a firm conviction of its success, arising out of his own experience is evident from the two passages given below:

1. I admit that my proposal is novel. But novelty is no crime. I admit that it has not much experience behind it. But what experience my associates and I have encourages me to think that the plan, if worked faithfully, will succeed. . . . In no other way can primary education be made free, compulsory and effective.

2. I can speak from experience. I had no difficulty in giving at Tolstoy Farm (Transvaal) all-round development to the boys and girls for whose training I was directly responsible. The central fact there was vocational training for nearly eight hours. They had one or, at the most, two hours of book learning. The vocations were digging, cooking, scavenging, sandal-making, simple carpentry and messenger work. The age of the children ranged from six to sixteen.

It is interesting to know that, at Tolstoy Farm in South Africa, he trained his own sons and other children through some manual training, e.g., carpentry or shoe-making. This, he says, he 'learned from

Kallenbach who had his training in a Trappist monastery'.¹

In the foregoing we have, in Gandhiji's own words, his ideas on education, the plan of the new education he recommends, and his conviction that the scheme will succeed 'if worked faithfully'. Unlike those of little faith, Gandhiji says: 'I have no such fears (of failure),

¹ A Trappist monastery is the residence of Trappist monks of the Catholic Church. They are so called after the Abbey of La Trappe in France, where the Abbot de Rancé introduced, in the seventeenth century, certain reforms in the earlier Religious Order of the Cistercians (called after Cîteaux in France and founded by St Robert in 1098), which itself developed out of the still earlier Order of Benedictines founded in Monte Cassino in Italy by St Benedict in the sixth century. What is noteworthy in the life of these monks (Benedictines, Cistercians and Trappists) is the importance attached to the dignity of manual labour. In the 'Rule of St Benedict' (the code regulating the life of the monks), chapter xlviii 'emphasizes the importance of manual labour and arranges the time to be devoted to it daily. This varies according to the season, but is apparently to be never less than about five hours a day.' (*Catholic Encyclopedia*, Vol. II, p. 438). So, too, with the Trappists whose day of twenty-four hours was divided thus: seven hours sleep; about seven hours also were devoted to the Divine Office and Mass (common prayers and worship); an hour for meals; four hours for study and private prayers; and five hours for manual labour; in winter there were only about four hours devoted to manual labour, the extra hour thus deducted being given to study. The monks were obliged to live by the labour of their hands, so the task appointed for manual labour was seriously undertaken, and was of such a nature as to render them self-supporting; such as cultivation of the land, cattle-raising, etc. (*Catholic Encyclopedia*, Vol. XV, pp. 24 and 25). Thus in Trappist monasteries, emphasis was laid on daily manual labour, and thereby the monks were self-supporting. In the schools under the Trappist monasteries, therefore, children were taught by the monks the dignity of human labour, and handicrafts formed an integral part of education and school life. Many, like Kallenbach, must have profited by this system of practical education under Trappist monks.

because I combine in myself the visionary and the practical-man.'

APPENDIX

*Mahatma Gandhi's Inaugural Address at
the Wardha Conference*

BROTHERS and SISTERS

I am thankful to you for the trouble you have taken in attending this Conference. You know that I have been asked to preside over this Conference; but it does not imply that I have to carry on the whole work singly. I have had very little responsibility in organizing this Conference. Sjt Shrimannarayanji who is the Organizing Secretary of the Marwari Education Society has taken great pains in convening it. It was he who first suggested to me the idea of convening a small conference to discuss my educational scheme on the occasion of the Silver Jubilee of the Education Society. I liked the idea and so here I am to place before you frankly all my ideas on national education which I have been adumbrating through the columns of *Harijan*. I am open to free and frank criticism so that I can clarify some misunderstandings in connexion with my scheme. The proceedings of the Conference will be mainly in Hindustani; and I think it is quite natural, although it may be slightly inconvenient to some of you to follow the proceedings in detail.

The ideas that I wish to place before you today are new in their method of presentation at least to me, although my experience behind those ideas is very old. The proposition that I wish to put forward refers to both primary and college education. But we will have to give special consideration to primary education. I have included secondary in primary education because primary education is the only education so-called that is available to a very small fraction of the people in our villages—many of which I have seen during my peregrinations since 1915. I have seen, perhaps more than anybody else, the conditions of Indian villages. I gained good experience

of the rural life of South Africa as well. I know fully well the type of education that is given in Indian villages. And now that I have settled down in Segaoan I can study the whole problem of national education from closer quarters. I am convinced that if we wish to ameliorate rural conditions we must combine secondary with primary education. The educational scheme therefore, that we wish to place before the country must be primarily for the villages. I have no experience of college education, though I have come in contact with hundreds of college boys, have had heart to heart chats and correspondence with them, know their needs, failings and the diseases they suffer from. But we must restrict ourselves to a consideration of primary education. For the moment the primary question is solved the secondary one of college education will be solved easily.

I am convinced that the present system of primary education is not only wasteful but positively harmful. Most of the boys are lost to the parents and to the occupation to which they are born. They pick up evil habits, affect urban ways and get a smattering of something which may be anything but education. What then should be the form of primary education? I think the remedy lies in educating them by means of vocational or manual training. I have some experience of it myself, having trained my own sons and other children on Tolstoy Farm in South Africa through some manual training, e.g. carpentry or shoe-making which I learned from Kallenbach who had his training in a Trappist monastery. My sons and all the children, I am confident, have lost nothing, though I could not give them an education that either satisfied him or them, as the time at his disposal was limited and his preoccupations were numerous.

But the scheme that I wish to place before you today is not the teaching of some handicrafts side by side with so-called liberal education. I want that the whole education should be imparted through some handicraft or industry. It may be objected that in the middle ages only handicrafts were taught to students; but the occupational training then, was far from serving an

educational purpose. The crafts were taught only for the sake of the crafts, without any attempt to develop the intellect as well. In this age those born to certain professions have forgotten them, have taken to clerical careers and are lost to the countryside. As a result, it is now impossible to find an efficient carpenter or smith in an average village. The handicrafts were nearly lost and the spinning wheel, being neglected, was taken to Lancashire where it was developed, thanks to the English genius, to an extent that is seen today. This, I say, irrespective of my views on industrialism.

The remedy lies in imparting the whole art and science of a craft through practical training and there-through imparting the whole education. Teaching of takli-spinning, for instance, presupposes imparting knowledge of various varieties of cotton, different soils in different provinces of India, the history of the ruin of the handicraft, its political reasons which will include the history of British rule in India, a knowledge of arithmetic, and so on. I am trying the same experiment on my little grandson who scarcely feels that he is being taught, for all the while he plays and laughs and sings. I am especially mentioning the takli and emphasizing its utility, because I have realized its power and its romance; also because the handicraft of making cloth is the only one which can be taught throughout the country, and because the takli is very cheap. If you have any other suitable handicraft to suggest, please do so without any hesitation so that we can consider it as well. But I am convinced that the takli is the only practical solution of our problem, considering the deplorable economic conditions prevailing in the country. The constructive programme of khadi since 1920 has led to the formation of Congress Ministries in seven provinces, and their success also depends on the extent to which we carry it out.

I have placed the scheme before the Ministers; it is for them to accept it or to reject it. But my advice is that primary education should centre round the takli. During the first year everything should be taught through the takli: in the second year other processes also can be

taught side by side. It will also be possible to earn quite enough through the takli because there will be sufficient demand for the cloth produced by the children. Even the parents of the children will be sufficient to consume the products of their children. I have contemplated a seven-year course which so far as the takli is concerned would culminate in practical knowledge of weaving, including dyeing, designing, etc.

You should bear in mind that this primary education would include the elementary principles of sanitation, hygiene, nutrition, of doing their own work, helping parents at home, etc. The present generation of boys knows no cleanliness, no self-help, and is physically weak. I would therefore give compulsory physical training through musical drill.

I have been accused of being opposed to literary training. Far from it! I simply want to show the way in which it should be given. The self-supporting aspect has also been attacked. It is said, whereas we should be expending millions on primary education we are going to exploit the children. It is also feared that there will be enormous waste. This fear is also falsified by experience. As for exploiting or burdening the children, I would ask whether it is burdening the child to save him from a disaster? Takli is a good enough toy to play with. It is no less a toy because it is a productive one. Even today children help their parents to a certain extent. The Segaon children know the details of agriculture better than I, from having worked with their parents in the fields. Whilst the child will be encouraged to spin and help his parents with agricultural jobs, he will also be made to feel that he does not belong only to his parents but also to the village and to the country, and that he must make some return to them. That is the only way. I would tell the Ministers that they will make children helpless by doling out education to them. They will make them self-confident and brave by making them pay for their own education with their own labour. This system is to be common to all—Hindus, Muslims, Parsees and Christians. Why do I not lay any stress on religious

instruction? people ask. Because I am teaching them practical religion, the religion of self-help.

The State is bound to find employment, if needed, for all the pupils thus trained. As for teachers, Prof Shah has suggested the method of conscription. He has demonstrated its value by citing instances from Italy and other lands.

I therefore ask you to say whether this imparting of education through manual training appeals to you. For me, to make it self-supporting will be a test of its efficiency. The children ought at the end of seven years to be able to pay for their instruction and be earning units.

College education is largely an urban proposition. I will not say that it is an unmitigated failure, as primary education is, but the results are fairly disappointing. Why should any one of the graduates have to be unemployed?

Takli I proposed as a concrete instance because Vinoba has the largest amount of practical experience in it, and he is here to answer our objections, if any. Kakasaheb will also be able to tell you something, though his experience has been more theoretical than practical. He has especially drawn my attention to Armstrong's *Education for Life*, and particularly the chapter on 'Education of the Hand'. The late Madhusudan Das was a lawyer, but he was convinced that without the use of our hands and feet our brain would atrophy, and even if it worked it would be the home of Satan. Tolstoy taught the same lesson through many of his tales.

We have communal quarrels—not that they are peculiar to us. England also had its Wars of the Roses. . . . If we want to eliminate communal strife, and international strife, we must start with foundations pure and strong by rearing our younger generation on the education I have adumbrated. That plan springs out of non-violence. I suggested it in connexion with the nation's resolve to effect complete prohibition, but I may tell you that even if there was to be no loss of revenue, and our exchequer was full, this education would be a *sine qua non* if we did not want to urbanize our boys. We have to make them

true representatives of our culture, our civilization, of the true genius of our nation. We cannot do so otherwise than by giving them a course of self-supporting primary education. Europe is no example for us. It plans its programmes in terms of violence because it believes in violence. I would be the last to minimize the achievement of Russia, but the whole structure is based on force and violence. If India has resolved to eschew violence, this system of education becomes an integral part of the discipline she has to go through. We are told that England spends millions on education, America also does so, but we forget that all that wealth is obtained through exploitation. They have reduced the art of exploitation to a science, and may well give their boys the costly education they do. We cannot, will not, think in terms of exploitation, and we have no alternative but this plan of education which is based on non-violence.